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Charles Tolliver
Part II

Part II was conducted via Zoom on May 21, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have a follow up session with Charles Tolliver. Welcome, sir, nice to see you again.

CT: Good to see you.

MR: You said something at the end of our first interview that has been on my mind so I wanted to follow up, and it had to do with, I believe the date was August 5th, 1964, your first recording experience with Jackie McLean. And you described a rehearsal process and Alfred Lion had his stopwatch.

CT: Yes.

MR: I wonder if you can tell me what time was he keeping?

CT: Well he was timing the — each song as we went through it in the rehearsal. And based on his experience he would generally, along with whoever is the leader, determine how many choruses you would make, based on the timing of the head of the song. So if a song was a minute probably you would get a couple of choruses. The leader could play as long as he liked.

MR: So maybe, I'm thinking that you're thinking in your head I'm going to be the leader someday and I'm going to get to play as long as I —

CT: No. No, Not at all. It just was, just happy to be included you know, and to do my best.

MR: So on that day you described a rehearsal and then getting into a taxi and going to Van Gelder's studios. So am I correct that that whole record was rehearsed and recorded in one day?

CT: No. There was one day, maybe two, depending on the complexity of the songs. And then the next day everybody would file into a couple of Checker cabs. I guess if you had a Checker cab now it would be worth something on the antique car market you know.

MR: Right. A lot of that is being —

CT: With the little jumper seats facing the regular seats, you know, so you could get luggage in there, you could get three, four, maybe five passengers, two facing the other three.

MR: And a saxophone and a trumpet.

CT: Yeah all of that in the trunk and off we'd go. And that was the procedure for any Blue Note recording, other than, you know, musicians who had their own cars. They would drive to Rudy's studio.

MR: Did you wear headphones at that point?

CT: No.

MR: Okay. Everybody could hear?

CT: Yeah, there wasn't a practice of wearing earphones. I mean I suppose they were in use but I don't recall any use of headphones. They were all in a sort of semi horseshoe set up, the piano the farthest away, and then bass and drums right together, no partitions or anything. And the horns facing the piano. So it was sort of like a little J type of thing. But the secret of Rudy Van Gelder was his microphones.

MR: Can you elaborate on that?

CT: Well he was using French Schoeps and special coverings for them, and a direct-to-master two track.

MR: Two track, yeah.

CT: But it was how he equalized everything coming in you know.

MR: I see. Well I'm struck by the fact that you mentioned showing up for this rehearsal and oh my God, there's Roy Haynes and Herbie Hancock, who actually was only — fairly close to age to you. And I just find it so interesting —

CT: Well he was 24, 23, 24. And me 21 or 22 you know.

MR: Yeah. Very exciting. So I was listening to something from a record you did years later in '72, it happened to have one of my favorite drummers Alvin Queen on it, and the record was "Impact." And I'm curious if the rehearsal time and recording time, how it compared to your first experience with Jackie McLean. Did you have more time, less time?

CT: Well that was a live recording.

MR: I see.

CT: I mean you know, I was heavily touring that band you know, during that period, especially in Europe. And we were at this famous club at the time called The Domicile in Munich. And that's where we recorded that.

MR: And Alvin is in Switzerland now.

CT: Yes he's living in Switzerland.

MR: Yes. I had a question that had to do with spirituality. And I think I'm guilty of for too long when people bring up spirituality I think of religion or faith. And I wanted to read something that Cecil McBee said in a conversation I had with him last November. And it was about spirituality and different periods in jazz. And he said, "well if it ain't spiritual don't play it. You know your spirit is what makes you play the instrument. If you're not spiritual you ain't feeling nothing. Elvin Jones used to say, 'if you ain't playing nothing get him off the stage and let someone else get up there and play it.'" So I don't really have a question, Charles, but does spirituality play a role in your composing and in your playing?

CT: Oh yeah. I basically want to have a spiritual connection to the musicians that I'm performing with at the time and so I have their capabilities in mind. Sometimes when I'm writing something I says well so-and-so-and-so would probably like to solo off this or play this you know. So there is that spiritual connection to your fellow musicians you know, a lot when you're writing songs you know if you are looking for some sort of inspiration. And my inspiration generally is rhythmical, dealing with the drums you know. Because I write a lot off of inspirational drum things.

MR: Is there something that could happen in your day to day life that might inspire you to run to your staff paper or your computer or your keyboard or whatever, and start working on it?

CT: Yeah. I mean that happens every day. A drum lick. I mean seriously you know it's not necessarily going to the piano and you know saying oh what's this little song that's going on in my head. It generally is coming off some sort of rhythmical thing that I hear between the drums and the bass. And then I'll put a melody to it and then chord changes if it needs some chord changes.

MR: That's always the hardest part for me is the chord changes, finding something that's interesting but — you had said, I really got a kick out of your story about learning about the minor nine chord in college, because I had the same experience except it was with the major seven. And for a while it was all about major sevenths. And eventually it got a little bit too happy for me so I had to —

CT: Well you know sometimes it's a lot more difficult to get some sort of solo activity out of major rather than minor. And as you probably know, I mean John Coltrane, he experimented with not playing in the minor you know, towards the end of his life you know. He did a lot of things off of a major feeling as opposed to a minor feeling.

MR: I've been reading a little bit about Sun Ra and that — I guess very experimental music that he did and others at that time. I wonder if you had any experience hearing him or groups like the Art Ensemble of Chicago, that were — I mean they were out there I guess is the best way I can put it. And I'm wondering if you'd ever heard them live?

CT: No, except for, you know of course Sun Ra, because I was coming up at the same time as when he was really at the forefront of what he was doing. But I didn't get a chance for any of us guys to rub shoulders together so to speak, during that period. But they carved out a niche in this and, you know, a lot of it had to do with musical theater. You know? Which struck a lot of fans as very interesting and palatable and so rather than coming to a performance in bow tie you know, they would come to hear these fellows who stripped away all of those formalities, both musically and visually you know. And it worked for them. I mean 'til now you have legions of followers of Sun Ra's output.

MR: Which was considerable.

CT: Yeah. And Marshall, he's still alive and occasionally brings a band, much younger players who weren't even born when they first started, now.

MR: They seem to have had the experience of going to Europe, certain parts, during that length of time they were together.

CT: Well the Europeans love musical theater. You know? And so definitely, I mean 'til now, they have revivals. Maybe not every year but, and then younger music folk get a chance to find out what that's all about and see if they like it. So it continues on that way.

MR: Did you find reception to your groups different in England and the continent than in the United States?

CT: No. It just was, depending on what year it was or the particular time it was just more accessible, there were a lot more music fans into the music that was being produced at that time. So you would have a rather large gathering whenever you played somewhere, as opposed to here you know. That was the difference. They had done their homework, these fans, and so they were there to really soak in this American art form you know. And so I didn't see a difference in, I mean you were playing to fans that knew that you were coming and so they showed up. And it would be the same in the States just less.

MR: I see.

CT: That's all. Same fervor, same fans just less. Because it's a special occasion when you were overseas so they would be really nice concerts set up a lot through government radio and television and things like that. And there were of course the underground club scene or whatever, and a few clubs there on the level of the New York style clubs, and other jazz venues across the United States. When I was coming up one of the ways that the livelihood of our most known jazz heroes was done through touring the black theater in the major cities you know. Well that was that theater that had live shows, like the Apollo. So you had a number of Apollo-like theaters in the major cities across the United States, and a band would come into the town and play that theater in between the movies. The movies would be shown, you know, Hop-A-Long Cassidy, you name it. And then the band will come on and play. Now of course who knows who out there in the audience was listening. But that, the tours were made that way. You know you would play the Howard Theaters, like in Washington, DC and the Apollo and other theaters like that in the black districts across the United States of course whatever was the main nightclub, you know, in that town.

MR: A number of people I've talked to, as in their formative years mentioned how effective it was when the band would rise up from the pit, especially if it was a big band. And they never forgot that sound and that sight of those musicians just appearing like that.

CT: Yeah. Well of course the two major venues that New York City fostered was the Cotton Club and the Savoy. You know I didn't get a chance to see the Cotton Club although it

was still there when my family got here to New York, but it wasn't functioning like it was in the heyday, or the earlier part of last century. And the Savoy was still there. In fact I wanted to know where that was so I kind of meandered over to where it was one day and standing out front was Idrees Sulieman. Then I was to find out later that was who I met. But you know I asked him you know is this the Savoy? And he was very nice to me, thought I was this young little kid you know, ten years old. And lo and behold I would get a chance to meet him and know him. You know years after I broke in, you know, coming through Copenhagen which is where he emigrated to. Both he and Sahib Shihab were, and, towards the end of his life as well, Ben Webster, they were all residents of Copenhagen you know.

MR: Do you think —

CT: I think that Idrees and Sahib Shihab, they finally came back home before they passed away, but Ben Webster, he passed away in Copenhagen.

MR: Do you think they found what they were looking for over there?

CT: Oh absolutely. They had a chance to play more in the well known Montmarte in the case of Copenhagen you know, and just appreciated. You know they were loved by the localities where they lived you know, treated as high artists.

MR: Yeah, like Sidney Bechet was sort of the king of that, I think, going to France.

CT: Yup.

MR: Very popular.

CT: Yeah. Well it was another time. The whole world was different then you know.

MR: Well you lead me into something that I was debating about asking and it's not a musical question but speaking of the whole world or maybe our country, how are you feeling about the state of our country today, current events?

CT: Well to put my mind on that you know, if I weren't a musician I'd be a warrior in that. But I mean it's just going to take a lot more percentage of good people, good humans, to outlast the bad ones you know. And we seem to have a little bit more percentage of good people. If we didn't, I mean the United States right now might not be livable for a lot of folks. But we do have some stopgaps you know. I mean right now you have to really knuckle down with the people that we've elected to control the government. And as long as they do that we could outlast the situation that is going on right now. Because luckily in this country the type of insurrection that happened on 1/6 absolutely is an aberration because of the way our system is set up. That sort of thing could never succeed. But it did put the rest of the world on notice that, you know, there are some knuckleheads here that would try that, like what they go through every few years elsewhere, excepting that the type of representative government we have, and that percentage of 60/40, sometimes 70/30, but 60/40 you know enables us to overcome these periods when this sort of

representative government is tested, just by crazy folks who, they know that they are, but they can't help themselves. They're doubling down on it because it's how they were brought up. They didn't just learn to be this way you know, it's how they were brought up. And so we'll have to see you know. Every decades or so this country's going to go through that. And just have to make sure that those pillars that have been set up to handle this are actually, you know, steadfastly used to repel as what happened with this latest one. And luckily we have the right folks in government right now. Because if it had been the other way around, truly the country would be facing a serious confrontation, deadly confrontation I would say. So we'll see.

MR: Well thanks for sharing your opinions about that. I was very happy to learn from you on the phone about the upcoming celebration of Strata-East Records. And could you tell me a little bit about that?

CT: Well things got up and running in 1971, you know, brought about by dearly departed Stanley Cowell and myself. And it was probably at the right moment that something like that could be done. Because there was a vacuum that had been created for bringing on new guys into recording and getting them out there like it was with the Blue Notes and Prestiges and all the other smaller independent labels who were issuing product. And it sort of was a labor of love so to speak, and just little by little you know it started to catch on with some musicians and we started issuing product and mom'd and pop'd it along.

MR: Good phrase.

CT: Basically mom'd and pop'd it along 'til now you know. It wasn't going for the big home run you know, just getting a product out there where the fans would get a hold of it. It was a lot easier in the first ten years because you had record stores and as long as you kept the records in the bins somehow, most of the fans of the music they'd pick up on it.

MR: Do you still have original copies of the 60 plus records that Strata-East issued?

CT: I wish I had. I mean but there are people who do have them.

MR: Yes.

CT: And they go for a very hefty — you know — in order, if you want to get one. I mean I have a number of them but I don't think I have all the ones that came through, the first, because most of them came through in the first ten years you know.

MR: I think you and I ought to start a, oh I don't know, a GoFundMe so we can get you all your original Strata-East records back.

CT: Oh boy. Well yeah, you'd get some hefty funding there maybe.

MR: Yes. We'll have to write a grant. You spoke a little bit about Andrew Hill and how you credit him with his approach to instruction about how to play his music?

CT: No not instruction, just observing how he allowed the people that he had gathered for whatever, a recording or performances, to interpret the music without being dogmatic as

to how he wanted it done. Yeah. But he always chose rhythm section guys that really helped set it up because they knew, you know, how he probably wanted things to go. And of course I think he probably always worked things out with his rhythm section before he would bring in horns and then so when you showed up, you know, the way to interpret it was already there you know, and so that approach stayed with me and I was grateful to have had an opportunity to basically from time to time perform with Andrew at the beginning of my career you know. I mean right off the bat, 1964 actually you know.

MR: Is it possible for you to describe the thought process that is occurring when you're improvising?

CT: I have a staff — continuous staff — running in front of me virtually in my consciousness, and I'm sort of putting notes on there as the staff is running along, and catching those notes on the instrument. Of course this is all simultaneous, instantaneously going on. It's a lot easier if you've got a slower tempo.

MR: That's true.

CT: Whereas a breakneck speed then the brain is really firing off you know, in my case. That's basically it. I have a virtual —

MR: That's fascinating. I never heard anybody describe it quite that way.

CT: Yeah. That staff is empty until the song starts. Well the song is basically memorized to play it, you know, and then up comes the staff. But sometimes I don't use my mind to bring the staff up. And sometimes it just shows up you know. And usually that's when I get exploratory you know. I start rumbling with the notes you know.

MR: Good phrase. If you had a student, if you said that to a student and they said — well why should I pretend I'm just going to say it, what do you mean by "exploratory"?

CT: Not playing what you practiced, that you know is absolutely perfect for the chord changes.

MR: And is there anything that constitutes a mistake or a wrong note for you?

CT: Only if you can't correct it. So that comes with years of experience you know. Doorbell — You're going to have to cut this

MR: Well I've had that discussion about wrong notes with a number of people and they agree with you, you're going to play them you just have to deal with it.

CT: Well there are no wrong notes. What I mean by that is not intentionally — saxophones, you know because of the pads and they have to use all of their fingers. They have a lot more possibilities for covering what they might consider a mistake. But you know for brass, the trumpet, you have no such support you know. You have these three valves and you have three fingers to work with. Everything you do has to be controlled by your diaphragm and your embouchure. And your embouchure will, I mean sometimes the setup is just, it won't respond right. And it also depends on your dental setup and you

know you have to know how the trumpet — when there's a danger that it's not that you don't know what you want to do and where you want to go with something you know, it's how well the embouchure is set up to deliver it.

MR: Do you have a regimen that you do to try to stay healthy and as capable of playing what's in your head and physically making it happen?

CT: Yes. To not abuse myself in any form so that my physical self will be able to deliver, then it's about how well I utilize that with the instrument. I don't have a routine you know.

MR: You had mentioned over the years if you had a person in your band, I think the way you put it was they were engaging in something they needed to do what they were doing somewhere else. And it seems certain eras of jazz that —

CT: Did I say that?

MR: You said that. It was a nice way to put it. If you're going to do that do it with someone else.

CT: Well I might have been referring to how I have observed, you know, those few instances when a musician may have, by the way — not by what they say but by the way they perform when they're playing with you that their minds and persona is not as a team player. You know. And in that case it would be better for them to do their own thing or go do it somewhere else. But generally — it really depends on the flavor and what is the aspirations of anyone that calls you for a gig or what you want to have happen, you know, on the bandstand for your own gig. And that's by sorting it out, you know, different musicians, seeing how they work and perform with you and — the good thing is that there are good choices. You don't have to be locked down with just one set of guys. And that's always been the case, mostly, excepting in the case when, you know, some iconic situations develop with a certain group of men, which is how this art form basically propels itself. You know we had about four or five major groups that was comprised of the same individuals for a number of years. And they helped to, you know, propel the art form forward by what they did together you know. And I think it's a great example of, you know, the word "repertorial" of one group of players playing a set repertoire over or a style of repertoire over a number of years you know. That's really repertory.

MR: Are you speaking of people like Charles Mingus and Ellington?

CT: Oh absolutely. Absolutely. But also Max Roach and Clifford Brown. They created a repertory that will live forever, a repertory of using the Great American Songbook, as well as their own compositions, and putting arrangements to them that will last forever. I mean the show — Broadway writers had no idea that those beautiful songs that they wrote that became a part of the American Songbook could be completely made even better you know, with chord substitutions and rhythmical arrangements and rhythmical

displacement, and you know the American Songbook, if you are not a composer you don't need it because it's just so much to work with there, you know, that you can make arrangements out of. But I mean Mingus, I mean with the small group Mingus and, well, Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie, that model is still king as far as I'm concerned. If you're getting this, yes we have all this that's going on now, with these different types of musical theatrical events. But if you're not dealing with that model in some fashion, okay, it might be great music but it's not in this particular part of the art form. So yeah, Max Roach and Clifford Brown, that's a book, a repertory book all by itself. At least two or three Miles Davis' repertory bands, Horace Silver — you could spend your entire lifetime using that repertory or that style, Art Blakey the same thing. The great thing about Art Blakey as opposed to Horace Silver who was a pianist so he wrote all his material which is now our American Songbook basically. Jazz music songbook. But Art Blakey, he drew or put in his band, you know, on each instrument just incredible musicians who were great composers. So that's a whole repertory by itself you know, indispensable. Like Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie is indispensible, that model. Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers, especially the ones from the beginning through 1965, that's totally indispensable if you're going to be in this and have the validity. You have to know that material. And so, yeah.

MR: Well said. I'm going to —

CT: Well let's not forget Thelonious Monk. That's a whole 'nother category by itself. Because not only was he the underpinnings harmonically for modern jazz, but he was musical theater at the same time. I mean you couldn't make him up, you can't make that up you know, because I got a chance to actually be close enough to see — you know, actually to talk to him. But talking to him was like talking to a psychiatrist who didn't answer you back. You know. Yes. So the Thelonious Monk repertory is like Horace Silver. I mean it's like, you know, it's indispensable. It's a requirement. If you haven't dealt with that then you're missing on some validity you know. Now nobody may not tell any young fellow or anything like that, they have to already, it's just, they have to already have mother wit. You know what mother wit is? Mother wit, you have to already have it, to do that on your own, so that you don't have to copy it, you have to know it though. You have to know it.

MR: All right. Words of wisdom. I'm going to wrap up here with a question that I've been debating about asking. And I have two variations on it. So I'm going to try it out on you, Charles, what does music mean? Or what can music mean?

CT: Well I think that music, you were talking about spiritual at the beginning, music in whatever form it is to people around the world, whether they know it or not, but most of them do, that they have to have it at some point during the day you know, in order to get

through you know with life as a human being on this planet. And as I said in the previous session we did, you know Art Blakey said it best — you know what he said? Right?

MR: I'd like to hear it again.

CT: Well yeah, I mean he'd come off of a blistering song and say to the audience, "Thank you very much ladies and gentlemen" and that featured so-and-so, "and we are here to wash away the dust of your everyday life." And so that's it.

MR: I'll wrap up, this is like a tag on a good jazz tune I think. I picked out some things that you said in our first session that I thought were marvelous and put them into a paragraph for you. So this is Charles Tolliver: "Once I realized I could do something with this art form I just wanted to belong. It's a glorious adventure, my life's work. I have not a nanosecond of regret. I am my grandmother and mother. You finish what you start."

CT: Yes.

MR: So I want to thank you for starting and keeping going.

CT: Thank you. We just got to keep our health, I mean we manage to get past this mother of all pandemics in our lifetime, so hopefully we're going to be okay and get some music up to the Utica area of the country.

MR: That would be really nice. I'll see what I can do about that.

CT: Yeah. All right.

MR: Thank you very much and I hope your Strata-East event is fulfilling and goes very well.

CT: Well share it with your constituents — as Charlie Parker said, my worthy constituents from Massey Hall — and hopefully they'll try to get themselves into the virtual audience.

MR: Yup. All right Mr. Tolliver, thank you again for your time. It's been a real pleasure.

CT: My pleasure.